

I22

Herod the Great

The brilliant, ruthless king who rebuilt the temple and tried to kill the newborn King of the Jews.

Herod the Great ruled Judaea for Rome for more than thirty years. A gifted builder and shrewd politician, he rebuilt the temple on a grand scale. He was also deeply suspicious and cruel. The Jewish historian Josephus records that he executed one of his wives and three of his own sons when he feared plots against his throne. So when wise men arrived asking for the newborn "King of the Jews," Herod was troubled. He pretended he wanted to worship the child, then ordered the killing of Bethlehem's baby boys. Soon afterward he died. Herod's story shows the fear of a man clinging to power, set against the quiet arrival of the true King.

At a glance

Name	Herod, called "the Great" by later writers to set him apart from his sons
Family	From Idumea (Edom), son of Antipater. Sons included Archelaus, Herod Antipas and Philip
Reign	King of Judaea under Rome, 37–4 BC; named king by the Roman Senate in 40 BC
Death	c. 4 BC, at Jericho, after a painful illness (Josephus)
Building	The Jerusalem temple, Caesarea, Masada, the Herodium and more
Key people	The Magi; Joseph of Nazareth; Mary, mother of Jesus
Main passages	Matthew 2:1–22; Luke 1:5

"When Herod the king had heard these things, he was troubled, and all Jerusalem with him."

Matthew 2:3, KJV

The life of Herod the Great

Dates are approximate (BC). Most scholars date his death to 4 BC. A minority prefer 1 BC.

40 BC

Named king



Rome's choice

With help from Mark Antony and Octavian, the Roman Senate declares Herod king of Judaea. He has to fight for three years to take his kingdom. *Josephus, Antiquities 14*

37 BC

Jerusalem
taken



Reign begins

With Roman troops, Herod captures Jerusalem and becomes king in fact. He marries Mariamne, from the old Jewish royal family, to strengthen his claim.

Josephus, Antiquities 14

c. 20/19 BC

18th year



Temple rebuilding begins

Herod starts a vast rebuilding of the temple and its courts. Work continues long after his death; in Jesus' day it had been "forty and six years" in building. *John*

2:20; Josephus, Antiquities 15

c. 6–4 BC

Wise men
arrive



Troubled

Magi ask for the newborn King of the Jews. Herod gathers the chief priests and scribes, meets the wise men secretly, and sends them to Bethlehem. *Matthew*

2:1–8

c. 6–4 BC

Bethlehem



The killing of the boys

Seeing that the wise men have mocked him by not returning, Herod in great anger orders every boy two years old and under in and around Bethlehem killed.

Matthew 2:16–18

c. 4 BC

At Jericho



Death

Herod dies, and an angel tells Joseph in Egypt that those who sought the child's life are dead. His kingdom is divided among his sons. *Matthew 2:19–22; Josephus,*

Antiquities 17

Key activities

Only Matthew records the killing of the infants. Bethlehem was a small town, so many scholars think the number of boys was small. Josephus does not mention it, though it fits the cruelty he describes.

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- 1 **Built on a grand scale.** He rebuilt the temple, whose stones impressed even Jesus' disciples. *Mark 13:1; John 2:20*
 - 2 **Was troubled by a rival.** News of a born King of the Jews alarmed him, and all Jerusalem with him. *Matthew 2:2-3*
 - 3 **Consulted Scripture for the wrong reason.** He asked the chief priests and scribes where the Christ would be born, planning to find him. *Matthew 2:4-6*
 - 4 **Deceived the wise men.** He said, "that I may come and worship him also." *Matthew 2:7-8*
 - 5 **Killed the innocent.** In anger he had the boys of Bethlehem "from two years old and under" killed. *Matthew 2:16*
 - 6 **Failed to stop God's plan.** Joseph had already fled with the child to Egypt, and Herod died soon after. *Matthew 2:13-15, 19-20*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name Herod the Great.

Old Testament

Jeremiah 31:15	"Rachel weeping," fulfilled in Bethlehem (Matthew 2:17-18)
Micah 5:2	The prophecy the scribes quoted to Herod
Echo: Exodus 1:22-2:10	Pharaoh kills baby boys, but Moses is saved
Echo: Psalm 2:2	Rulers set "against the LORD, and against his anointed"

New Testament

Matthew 2:1-22	The main account
Luke 1:5	"In the days of Herod, the king of Judaea"
Luke 3:1; Mark 6:14-29	His sons; Antipas killed John the Baptist
Acts 12:1-23	His grandson Agrippa I kills James and is struck down
Tradition	Saying attributed to Augustus: better Herod's pig than his son; unconfirmed

For discussion

1. *Observe:* How did Herod react when he heard about the newborn King (Matthew 2:3, 16)?
2. *Understand:* Herod knew the Scriptures' answer but used it to harm, not to worship. How can people know facts about God yet oppose him?
3. *Apply:* Herod feared losing control. Where are you tempted to hold on to control rather than trust God?
4. *Apply:* The families of Bethlehem suffered real loss. How can your group care for someone who is grieving now?